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Summarize the 1906 San Francisco Earthquake. What factors shaped the current landscape?

The 1906 San Francisco Earthquake was one of the most devastating natural disasters in U.S. history, striking early in the morning on April 18, 1906.

What happened

- A massive rupture along the San Andreas Fault caused a quake estimated around magnitude 7.8.
- Violent shaking lasted less than a minute, but the damage was catastrophic.
- Much of the destruction came **afterward**, when fires broke out across San Francisco and burned for several days.
- Around **3,000 people died**, and over **200,000 were left homeless**—more than half the city's population at the time.

Why it was so destructive

Several factors made the disaster worse:

- **Poor construction**: Many buildings were made of wood and not designed to withstand earthquakes.
- **Broken infrastructure**: Water mains ruptured, making it nearly impossible to fight fires.
- **Urban density**: Crowded neighborhoods allowed fires to spread rapidly.
- **Limited emergency response**: Coordination and communication systems were primitive.

How it shaped today's landscape

1. Modern earthquake science

- The quake led to the first major scientific study of earthquakes in the U.S.
- It advanced understanding of fault movement and elastic rebound theory along the San Andreas Fault.

2. Building codes and engineering

- Cities in California adopted **stricter building codes**.
- Today's structures in San Francisco are designed with seismic safety in mind (flexible frames, reinforced materials).

3. Urban redesign

- Large parts of the city were rebuilt, sometimes with **wider streets** and improved layouts.
- Infrastructure systems (water, transportation) were redesigned for resilience.

4. Emergency preparedness

- The disaster highlighted the need for coordinated emergency response systems.
- Modern disaster planning, drills, and early warning systems trace back to lessons learned here.

5. Regional growth patterns

- Some residents permanently relocated, helping shape development in nearby Bay Area communities.
- The rebuilding effort also accelerated economic recovery and modernization.

Big picture

The 1906 earthquake wasn't just a catastrophe—it became a turning point. It transformed how cities prepare for natural disasters, how engineers design buildings, and how scientists understand earthquakes. Much of what defines earthquake readiness in California today can be traced back to the lessons learned in 1906.

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